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deployed in this programme, to be called the STP.

- The entire cost of this experiment would be borne by Infosys.
- Every candidate would be provided with a decent stipend by Infosys.
- The candidates would be provided with excellent breakfast, lunch and dinner by Infosys since I have discovered that students often skip these basic necessities and spend money on other not-so-necessary items. Lack of proper nutrition often comes in the way of students focusing on studies.
- The teachers would be courteous, patient, mission-oriented and willing to spend as much time as the students wanted in solving problems posed by them. Maintaining the hope, enthusi-

Caste away: The Government should run training programmes for SC and ST students

asm and confidence of the students in this difficult experiment was very important.

► The students would undergo exactly the same recruitment procedure as at campus recruitments. The training process would be such that they would found suitable by almost all the major software companies.

► While conducting this experiment, we would create systems, processes and collaterals to enable the state governments to scale up this programme to be run throughout the country.

► While the first experiment would be funded by Infosys, the subsequent ones would have to be funded by the social welfare agencies of the government.

► The only expectation that the STP would have from the students is that they should believe in themselves, be aspirational, honest, hard-working and disciplined.

R.B. Agwane, secretary, Department of Social Welfare of Karnataka Government, managed to enroll 89 engineering graduates (35 girls and 54 boys) from the SC and ST communities. Nandan Nilekani, our then CEO, and Kris Gopalakrishnan, our then COO, were, as usual, supportive of such a socially-important programme and signed a cheque for Rs 1 crore without batting an eyelid. Sadagopan and Ravindra went ahead with their usual, missionary zeal to select the most-committed faculty members from IIT-B and Infosys. Pai became the sponsor of my yet another crazy idea and provided leadership for it to happen. Thanks to Balu Doraiswamy, HP donated 100 laptops for the students. M.B.N. Rao, chairman of Canara Bank, was kind enough to provide classroom facilities for the students in the city. After ascertaining that we were, indeed, ready to start the programme, I contacted Mrs Kumar and told her about my experiment. She was, as always, very encouraging. When one of her officers suggested that she should inaugurate it, I told her that we wanted her name to be associated with this experiment only when it became a success. That is, when at least 90 per cent of the students completing the programme had been placed with well-known software companies. This figure is much higher than the success rate of students from engineering colleges through normal campus recruitments. I also told her that I did not want any inauguration till the experiment was a success since it would put the